Britain’s contribution was negative because of grudges from the past and imperial considerations, which saw the establishment of the State of Israel as contrary to Britain’s interests in the Middle East.

In light of all this, the young Israeli government, which was waging a war with one hand and dealing with the absorption of Holocaust survivors with the other, found itself facing enormous pressure from the rest of the world. Because of its refusal to agree to completely impossible conditions, it was losing the sympathy of the international community, to the point that comparisons were being made between the Zionist actions vis-à-vis the Arabs in the Land of Israel with the actions of the Nazis against the Jews during the Third Reich! At home, too, the government did not enjoy a consensus.

While in the process of formulating the agreement to accept 100,000 refugees, the government attempted another move intended to demonstrate that it was willing to compromise and perhaps gain some sympathy from the international community, and especially from the United States. On June 15, 1949, Foreign Minister Sharett announced a family reunification plan in the Knesset that would enable families who were split up during the fighting to reunite in Israel. There was much hubbub surrounding the announcement of this plan within Israel and among its supporters, but the results were underwhelming. By September 20, 1951, about 2,000 refugees had entered Israel under this program; it was a drop in the ocean, and it did not ease the pressure on the government in the slightest.

On July 5, 1949, Sharett suggested during a cabinet meeting that Israel declare its readiness to absorb 100,000 refugees in exchange for peace. Most of the ministers supported the proposal, but Ben-Gurion objected. It was therefore agreed to put out feelers to see if the suggested number would indeed even satisfy the Americans. To make a long story short, Secretary of State Acheson’s response was a demand for 250,000 refugees. President Truman, on the other hand, thought (according to the testimony of one of his aides) that the 100,000 offer might break the deadlock. On July 28, Israel officially announced its willingness to absorb 100,000 refugees. The announcement sparked a domestic political storm, with the voices against it surpassing those who were in favor. Once again, the Arabs made Israel’s job easy by rejecting the Israeli proposal out of hand and refusing even to discuss it.